TURNCOAT'S TRIUMPH



It's long been a grouse with BJP veterans in Maharashtra that new imports to the party walk away with the plum posts. Now they have one more appointment to complain about, with the saffron party choosing two-term corporator, **Ritu Tawde,** as the mayor of Mumbai. Tawde is an ex-Congress functionary who joined the BJP in 2012.

LANGUAGE WARS





In a Rajya Sabha debut that lit up social media, veteran actor-turned-neta **Kamal Haasan** turned a linguistic squabble into parliamentary theatre. Responding to a remark attributed to Union minister **Nirmala Sitharaman** that learning Tamil wouldn't "help in anything other than begging", he retorted that while languages like English and Hindi may be used to seek alms or "even steal", Tamil can do neither. "A Tamilian will not beg," Haasan said, "and he'll certainly not accept your alms."

TITLE TROUBLE



Forget content, now even titles can get you into trouble. The Uttar Pradesh government has registered an FIR against Netflix's upcoming **Manoj Bajpayee**-starrer *Ghooskhor Pandit*, claiming it has hurt Brahmin sentiments. But does the word 'pandit' imply expertise, or does it hint at collective corruption by a community? The government says the move was preventive, but critics call it political pressure. Meanwhile, the filmmakers—director Neeraj Pandey is himself a Brahmin—have withdrawn the trailer but say they stand by the film's "intent".

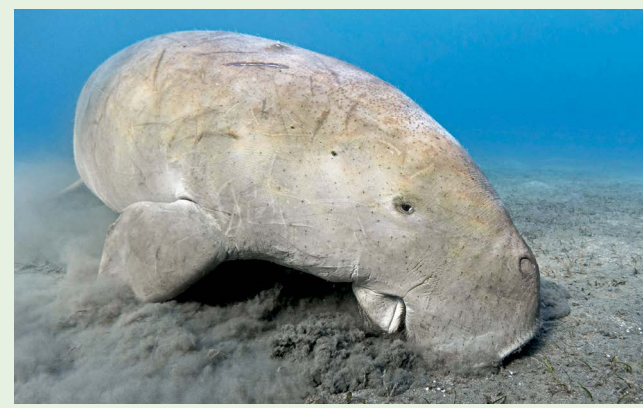
Kaushik Deka with Jumana Shah, Ashish Misra, Dhaval S. Kulkarni, Kavitha Muralidharan and Avaneesh Mishra

ECO WATCH

ENDANGERED MAMMALS
SEA COWS COME HOME

By **Jumana Shah**

India's fragile dugong population is showing signs of stability, with a new Wildlife Institute of India (WII) study estimating 270 individuals along the Tamil Nadu coast—the country's largest and most viable population of the endangered marine mammal. The survey, done along with the Tamil Nadu forest department, found 158 dugongs in Palk Bay and 112 in the Gulf of Mannar. India's dugong population was previously believed to be fewer than 250 individuals nationwide, scattered across fragmented habitats.



Dugongs (*Dugong dugon*), often called 'sea cows', are slow-breeding, herbivorous marine mammals that depend entirely on seagrass ecosystems. Their survival is closely tied to healthy coastal habitats, making them a key indicator species for marine ecosystem health. Historically, dugongs were more widely distributed across Indian waters. Today, their presence is restricted to four regions: the Gulf of Mannar and Palk Bay in Tamil Nadu, the Gulf of Kutch in Gujarat, and the Andaman and Nicobar Islands. Populations along India's eastern coastline have largely disappeared.

Earlier, scientific assessments had suggested small populations of about 25 individuals in Gujarat's Gulf of Kutch and scattered sightings in the Andaman and Nicobar Islands. Dugongs have a slow reproductive cycle and face threats from fishing nets, seagrass habitat loss, pollution and coastal development. The new study forms part of India's dugong recovery programme, which focuses on monitoring populations, protecting their habitats, and reducing human-induced threats.